

bike, on travel and on social outings. He was a generous man who stood by his friends. But most of the loans he gave to them never came back. He got married in 1995 at the age of twenty-eight and that didn't change his lifestyle much. It was only when Akanksha was born in 1996 that Kusum and he realized the need to build a financial buffer.

Mr Talwar booked his first fixed deposit (FD) within a few days of Akanksha's birth. Over the years, FDs remained his preferred investment. The Talwars also kept buying gold, whenever possible, as jewellery for Kusum. Gold not only conformed to traditional wisdom (about it being a reliable store of value) but would also come handy when it was time for Akanksha to get married. Some of his colleagues would invest in stocks, but between 1991 and 2004 the Indian stock market was characterized by regular share price rigging scams, and Mr Talwar saw investors in stocks as punters. Like most well-educated Indians, he saw the stock market as an unknown area of darkness. In fact, he had seen most of his friends losing significant amounts of money every now and then in the stock market.

In 1999, Mr Talwar bought his first flat in Noida. This was more on the insistence of his parents who had scored a hat trick by pushing him into the three big decisions of his life—marriage, children and now the house! It was a matter of pride for them that their son owned a house at thirty-two years of age because they were only able to afford it in their fifties. The house was purchased using a home loan. In those days, interest rates were as high as 13 to 14 per cent. The monthly instalments forced the Talwars to live a hand-to-mouth existence for years. They had to break their FDs to buy the house. As a result, through their thirties all their savings were invested in real estate.

Thankfully, interest rates came down over the years and Mr Talwar's salary increased. As the burden of the monthly instalments eased, the family breathed easier. It allowed the Talwars to start saving again and they turned to their old friend—fixed deposits. But this time, Mr Talwar was a little more aggressive. In the post-2000 India, he bought stocks. This was based on the collective wisdom of a small group of stock investors in his office. In those days, stock investing meant trading. There was no concept of holding a stock for the long term. One bought a stock, watched it like a hawk and sold it once